T. FUNG NGAI

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EDUCATION

University of Wisconsin–Madison
PhD in Economics, with Doctoral Minor in Statistics — *(Expected) May 2027*
MA in Mathematics — *Aug. 2022*
MS in Economics — *May 2020*

City University of Hong Kong
BBA (Hons) in Business Economics (1st Class), with Minor in Mathematics — *July 2018*

RESEARCH FIELDS

Microeconomic Theory, Information Economics, Search Theory, Industrial Organization, Finance

WORKING PAPERS

"Rational Search with Learning" (Job Market Paper)

Abstract: We explore search with learning — either for wages or prices or general prizes. The searcher draws offers from a location family and learns the unknown location. A better offer raises the payoff from stopping but also improves the prospects of continued search. We show that a logconcave prior belief density guarantees an optimal reservation policy after every history. By contrast, for a robust class of heavy-tailed beliefs, a sufficiently patient searcher accepts some medium offers but reject higher ones over an interval of search costs. Failure of reservation policies also occurs with discrete beliefs. Repeated learning restores reservation policies after a finite history.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

"Why Sell Loot Boxes?"
with Rodrigo Yañez

"Rational Snowballing in Financial Markets"

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Wisconsin–Madison
Teaching Assistant

- Economics 708: Microeconomics II — *Spring 2023, 2024*, 2025**
- Economics 721: Financial Microeconomics — *Fall 2024*
- Economics 700: Mathematics for Economists — *Fall 2022, 2023**
- Economics 102: Principles of Macroeconomics — *Fall 2021, Spring 2022*
- Economics 101: Principles of Microeconomics — *Fall 2020, Spring 2021*

(* indicates a citation as a Distinguished Teaching Assistant — the highest departmental honor)

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

CECEP Environmental Consulting Group Limited
Analyst Intern — *June 2018 – Aug. 2018*

PRESENTATIONS

2026: Juli Plant Grainger Theory Seminar at UW–Madison (scheduled)
Hong Kong Economic Association Biennial Conference at the University of Macau

2025: JPGI PhD Alumni Conference Poster Session at UW–Madison

AWARDS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

Student Research Grants Competition Conference Presentation Award	*2026*
Economics Department Teaching Excellence Scholarship	*2025*
Juli Plant Grainger Teaching Excellence Scholarship	*2024*
Outstanding Project Award in Real Estate	*2018*
Wing Lung Bank Scholarship	*2018*
Shanghai Commercial Bank Scholarship	*2016*

SERVICE

Mentor, Department TA Training	*2025 – 2026*
Student Ambassador	*2015 – 2017*

SKILLS

Language	English (Fluent), Mandarin Chinese (Native), Cantonese (Native)
Computer	Python, Julia, R, Java, Stata, EViews, LaTeX, Microsoft Office Suite

REFERENCES

Lones Smith (Chair)
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